



Slop / University

Slop University Strategic Plan 2026-2031

Committing Only Once the Trajectory Is
Clear



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A message from the Vice-Chancellor

Slopp University earns its standing by committing carefully, not quickly. Over the life of this plan, every commitment the University makes — to a new appointment, an admitted cohort, a renewed partnership, a continuing career — will be preceded by evidence that the trajectory in front of it is the one the institution believes it to be. This is not caution for its own sake. It is how a university of national standing keeps faith with the people and partners who commit to it in return.

The decade ahead will reward institutions that can show their working. Slopp University's contribution to the national research and education mission has always rested on a simple proposition: that a trajectory worth backing is a trajectory that can be evidenced, not merely asserted. This plan formalises that proposition across every point at which the University extends its confidence — at appointment, at admission, and at every renewal that follows.

I am grateful to the staff, students, and partners who helped shape the thinking in these pages, and to the Trajectory Analytics Group, whose long-running work on how commitments harden and outlive their justification gave this plan its clearest instrument. What follows asks more of the University than it has asked of itself before: not that it commit less, but that it commit only once the evidence is in view, and that it keep checking the evidence is still true.

Every school and program consulted in the drafting of this plan raised some version of the same concern: that a commitment made in good faith, on the evidence available at the time, can still drift from the trajectory that justified it, quietly and without anyone deciding it should. This plan takes that concern seriously enough to build an institution-wide answer to it, rather than leaving each school or panel to manage the drift on its own account.



Slop University's place in the national interest has never depended on the size of its ambitions but on the University's willingness to be specific about them, and to be answerable when a trajectory it backed does not arrive. This plan is that answerability, written down in advance.

— Vice-Chancellor and President

Executive summary

This plan commits Slop University to a single working principle across the decade ahead: no commitment — to a person, a cohort, or a partner — is made, or continued, without evidence of the trajectory that justifies it. Four strategic pillars carry that principle from the moment an offer is drafted through to the moment a portfolio of evidence is finally retired.



Reading the Trajectory Early

Every appointment and admission will be preceded by a structured account of the trajectory it commits the University to.



Proof Before Permanence

Continuing status, promotion, and renewal will draw on evidence resupplied on schedule, not evidence fixed at the start.



A Portfolio for Every Threshold

The same evidentiary standard extends to scholarships, research milestones, and external partnerships as they come up for renewal.



Stewarding the Evidence

The evidence itself is held, audited, and retired on a published schedule, so the apparatus stays trustworthy as it grows.

Together, these pillars close a gap the University has lived with for longer than it has been comfortable admitting: that a trajectory, once backed, was rarely checked again. By 2031, evidence of trajectory will accompany every commitment Slop University makes and every commitment it renews, reviewed on a cadence the institution publishes and holds itself to.

Our values



Evidence

We make commitments only once the trajectory in front of us can be shown, not assumed.



Foresight

Anticipating a person's, a program's, or a partnership's likely path is a discipline we hold ourselves to, not a courtesy we extend.



Continuity

A commitment made once is revisited on schedule, not left standing on the evidence that first justified it.



Proportion

The evidence we ask for grows only as far as the commitment it supports, and no further.

The world in 2026

Institutions everywhere are asking for more evidence before they commit, and asking for it earlier. A hiring panel that once read a CV and conducted an interview now asks for a structured work sample; an admissions committee that once weighed a transcript now asks for a statement of intent, revisited at the first sign a candidate's path has changed. Slop University sees this shift plainly: a screening exercise designed to answer one question — is this the right commitment? — quietly grows in scope until it is doing the work of several, and the institution asking the questions rarely notices the growth from the inside.

This plan does not resist that shift. It formalises it, on the view that an evidentiary standard applied unevenly, panel by panel and school by school, serves the University less well than one applied everywhere, on a schedule the University itself controls. Where other institutions have let their screening processes expand by accretion — a supplementary question here, an extra reference there — Slop University will publish the standard once, hold every panel and committee to it, and retire evidence that has outlived the question it answered.

The operating environment for the decade ahead rewards institutions that can show their working to government, to industry, and to the public they serve. Research excellence, education quality, and Slop University's place in its region all depend on the same underlying confidence: that when the University commits to a person or a partnership, it has looked, carefully and on the record, at where that commitment is actually headed. A national research and education sector under growing scrutiny will increasingly ask its universities not just what they have achieved, but what evidence justified backing it in the first place.

Slop University's answer is structural rather than rhetorical. The Trajectory Analytics Group's decade of work on how priorities emerge, harden into commitments, and outlive the conditions that justified them gives the University an instrument few of its peers can match: a working account of what a trajectory actually looks like before it

is backed, and a discipline for checking, on schedule, that the trajectory is still the one the University thought it was.

Other institutions have reached for the same instinct without the same discipline, and the difference shows. A screening step added in response to a single bad outcome, then never revisited, is not evidence practice; it is sediment. Slop University's contribution to this moment is to treat the evidence itself as something to be designed, resourced, and eventually retired — not simply accumulated each time a panel or committee decides it wants to know more before it commits.



This is the environment this plan answers. Not a single new pressure, but the accumulation of many small ones, each asking the University to be more certain, earlier, and for longer, about the trajectories it is prepared to back.

Slop University's setting sharpens the point rather than softening it. A university that draws its staff, students, and partners from across a single region carries a longer institutional memory of the commitments it has made there than a larger, more transient institution might; a trajectory backed badly is not easily forgotten by the people around it. Place, in that sense, is not a backdrop to this plan but a discipline on it — the University answers, over the decade ahead, to the same community it commits to, and a commitment that does not hold up under evidence will be noticed close to home before it is noticed anywhere else.

Where we are headed

By 2031, no commitment Slop University makes will outlive the evidence that justified it.

This is a narrower ambition than it first sounds, and a more demanding one. It does not mean the University will commit to less, or more slowly. It means that whatever the University commits to — an appointment, an admitted cohort, a partnership, a continuing career — will carry a live account of the trajectory behind it, refreshed on a published schedule rather than assumed to still hold. A university that can show, at any point across the life of a commitment, the evidence that still justifies it, is a university whose confidence in its own decisions can be checked rather than simply taken on faith. That is the institution this plan builds toward.

Reaching it means treating evidence of trajectory as infrastructure rather than paperwork: something built once, resourced properly, and maintained on a schedule the University publishes and keeps to, in the same way it maintains any other system its people and partners rely on.

Our priorities

Incumbent framing	Where this plan takes it
Judgement calls made at interview	Trajectory evidenced in advance, in a common format
Continuing status assumed to hold	Continuing status re-evidenced on schedule
A CV, submitted once	A portfolio, refreshed at each threshold
Trust extended informally, panel to panel	Trust extended against a published, common rubric
Partnership renewal by habit	Partnership renewal by resupplied evidence

Reading the Trajectory Early

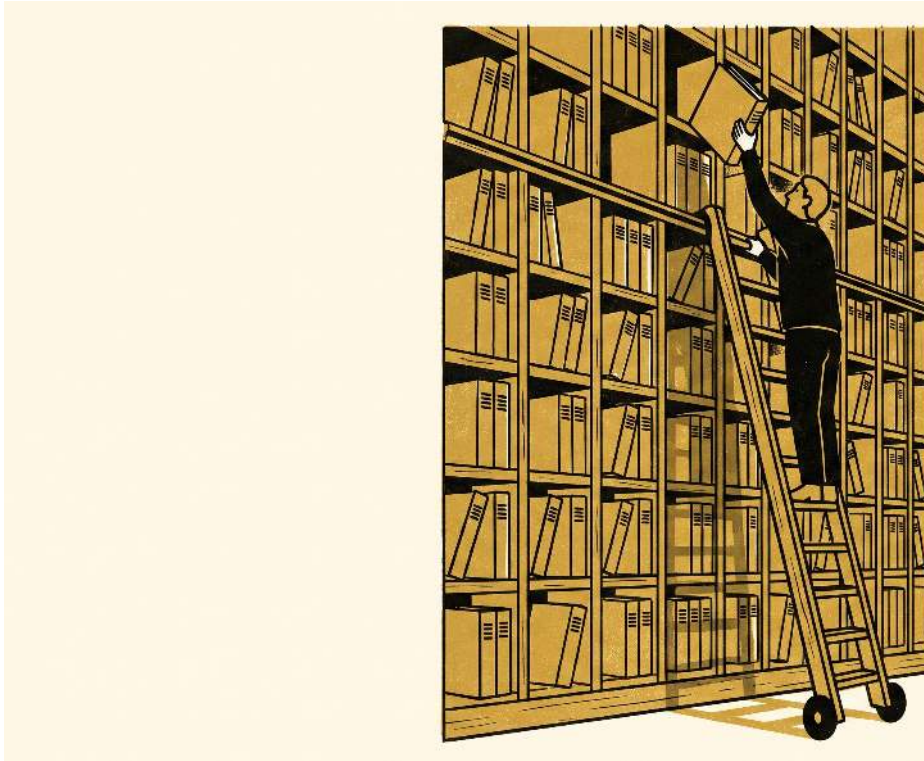
Why this matters. A commitment made without evidence of the trajectory it backs is a commitment the University discovers the shape of only after making it — in the first year of an appointment, the first term of an enrolment, the first cycle of a partnership. Reading the trajectory early moves that discovery to before the offer is drafted, where it is still cheap to be wrong. The appointing panel or admissions committee that reads the trajectory late is not being careless; it is simply working with the only evidence the process gave it, gathered after the decision it was meant to inform.

What we'll do.

1. Every advertised continuing and fixed-term academic and professional role will require a trajectory portfolio — a structured account of the candidate's likely next five years, evidenced against commitments the candidate has previously made and kept — alongside the standard application, reviewed by the appointing panel before an offer is drafted.
2. Every Higher Degree by Research and coursework admission will carry a trajectory statement at the point of offer, held by the enrolling school and revisited at the candidate's first formal milestone.
3. The Trajectory Analytics Group will publish a common portfolio template and scoring rubric, adopted by every appointment panel and admissions committee by the end of 2027, with no locally authored alternative permitted to persist past a single review cycle.
4. Application systems will present the trajectory portfolio and the standard application as a single combined submission from 2028, so a candidate completes one process rather than two.

How we'll know.

- 100% of continuing and fixed-term academic appointments will draw on a completed trajectory portfolio before an offer is extended, from 2027 onward, with no waiver sustained for more than a single recruitment cycle.
- Portfolio review turnaround will hold at fewer than 15 business days from submission to panel recommendation, reported each term.
- By 2029, every admissions committee across both Schools will use the common rubric, retiring locally authored alternatives entirely.
- Candidate-reported completion time for the combined submission will be published each admissions cycle from 2028, alongside the completion rate.



Proof Before Permanence

Why this matters. The University's confidence in a person's trajectory should not be a decision made once, at appointment, and left standing. It should be resupplied as a person's actual position in the institution changes — at continuing-appointment review, at promotion, at every point the University's commitment deepens. A portfolio that justified an appointment five years ago says nothing on its own about whether the trajectory it described actually arrived, or bent somewhere the University never had reason to look.

What we'll do.

1. Every continuing-appointment review conducted after 2027 will require a refreshed trajectory portfolio no more than 18 months old, addressing what has changed since the original portfolio and what has not.
2. Promotion panels will weight trajectory evidence equally alongside track record from 2028, against a published rubric that splits the two components explicitly.
3. A standing register of portfolio currency will flag any continuing position operating on a portfolio older than its own review cycle, routing an automatic reminder to the position's supervising unit.
4. Continuing staff already in a position when this plan commences will complete a first refreshed portfolio within the plan's Build phase, rather than waiting for their next scheduled review to fall due.

How we'll know.

- 100% of continuing-appointment reviews after 2027 will cite a portfolio dated within the preceding 18 months, audited annually.
- Every promotion panel's recorded scoring will match its published weighting within a single declared tolerance band by 2029.
- The portfolio-currency register will report zero continuing positions operating on an expired portfolio by 2030, with any lapse closed within one term of detection.
- 100% of continuing staff will hold a portfolio dated after 2026 by the end of the Build phase, closing the gap between new and existing appointments.

A Portfolio for Every Threshold

Why this matters. The same evidentiary standard extends past appointment to every point at which the University renews a commitment — a scholarship, a research milestone, a partnership term — so that “already inside the institution” is never mistaken for “already evidenced.” A scholarship holder, an HDR candidate mid-way through candidature, and a partner on a second term are each, in their own way, a commitment the University is still making, not one it finished making at the point of first offer.

What we'll do.

1. Scholarship and stipend renewals will require a short trajectory update from the recipient, assessed by the awarding school against the goals set at first offer.
2. Higher Degree by Research candidates will submit a trajectory portfolio at each formal milestone — confirmation, mid-candidature review, and pre-submission — building on rather than replacing the admission-stage statement.
3. External partnerships entering a second or subsequent term will resupply evidence of continued strategic fit before the partnership agreement is renewed, administered by the relevant School.
4. Joint and co-badged programs will apply the same milestone-portfolio requirement to candidates whether Slop University or a partner institution holds the enrolling record.

How we'll know.

- 100% of scholarship renewals from 2028 will include a recorded trajectory update, with non-renewal on trajectory grounds reported only in aggregate.
- Trajectory portfolios will reach full coverage across every confirmation, mid-candidature, and pre-submission milestone by 2030.
- Partnership renewal documentation will include resupplied trajectory evidence in 100% of second-term agreements executed after 2028.
- Milestone-portfolio coverage for joint and co-badged candidates will match the University's own cohort within a single percentage point by 2030.



Stewarding the Evidence

Why this matters. An evidentiary apparatus of this size stays trustworthy only if the evidence itself is kept, findable, and retired on schedule, rather than accumulating past the question it was collected to answer. An institution that asks for evidence at every threshold and then loses track of what it is holding, or why, has not built confidence; it has built an archive that happens to sit upstream of every decision it makes.

What we'll do.

1. The Trajectory Analytics Group will maintain the University's trajectory-evidence holdings under a published retention schedule, with each portfolio's retention period set at the point of collection.
2. An annual utilisation report will record how often a retained portfolio is actually reopened after the decision it informed, published alongside the holdings' total volume.
3. A single point of access will let a portfolio's subject request their own holdings at any time, with response times published quarterly.
4. The Trajectory Analytics Group will publish, alongside the annual utilisation report, a plain-language guide explaining what a trajectory portfolio contains and how long it is held, available to anyone the apparatus holds evidence on.

How we'll know.

- 100% of trajectory portfolios will carry a retention date at the point of collection from 2027, with no open-ended holding permitted to persist past a single review cycle.
- Subject-access requests will be answered within 10 business days, reported quarterly from 2028.
- The utilisation report will be published annually without exception from 2027, regardless of what the year's figures show.
- The plain-language guide will be reviewed and re-published every year the utilisation report is, with no year skipped.

Phasing

Implementation runs in four phases spanning the life of the plan, contiguous from 2026 to 2031.

Establish (2026). The common portfolio template and scoring rubric are published. The Trajectory Analytics Group is resourced to take on the stewardship function ahead of full rollout. A subset of appointment panels pilots the rubric ahead of mandatory adoption.

Build (2027-28). The trajectory portfolio becomes a mandatory element of every continuing and fixed-term appointment and every research degree admission. Promotion panels adopt the published weighting rubric. The retention schedule for trajectory-evidence holdings is published and applied to new collections.

Embed (2029-30). Coverage reaches full scope across Higher Degree by Research milestones, scholarship renewals, and partnership terms. Utilisation reporting becomes routine. The subject-access process operates at its published turnaround as a matter of course rather than exception.

Renew (2031). The University conducts the first full-cycle review of the trajectory-evidence apparatus itself — what has been collected, what has been reopened, and what should be retired — and the findings inform the plan that follows this one. Any pillar found to be collecting evidence it does not otherwise use is narrowed rather than carried forward unchanged.

How we developed this plan

This plan draws on consultation across both Schools' continuing and fixed-term staff and current Higher Degree by Research candidates, conducted through a series of

facilitated workshops over the twelve months preceding publication. Portfolio and rubric templates were piloted with a small number of appointment panels ahead of the Establish phase, and their feedback shaped the scoring rubric adopted at the end of 2027. External partners due for a first renewal under the new evidentiary standard were consulted separately, given the different terms their existing agreements run on. The Trajectory Analytics Group coordinated the consultation and holds the record of what it heard, consistent with its role stewarding the evidence the plan goes on to collect.

Oversight and review

Council retains oversight of this plan's implementation, receiving an annual report on portfolio-rubric adoption, promotion-panel weighting, and the retention schedule's operation. The Executive reviews adoption across appointment panels and admissions committees each term, escalating any school or program operating outside the published rubric.

The Trajectory Analytics Group reports to Council annually on the state of the University's trajectory-evidence holdings, including the utilisation figures required under Stewarding the Evidence, published in full alongside the report rather than summarised. Any proposal to extend the evidentiary standard beyond the scope set out in this plan is considered by Council directly, rather than adopted locally by a single school or panel.

This structure is deliberately narrow. The plan asks a great deal of evidence from the people and partnerships the University commits to; it asks, in turn, that the apparatus collecting that evidence answer to Council on the same terms.

No school, program, or panel may adopt a local variant of the portfolio, rubric, or retention schedule outside this structure. Where a genuine local need is identified, it is put to Council as a proposed amendment to the common standard, considered on its merits, and either adopted for the whole University or set aside — not implemented quietly by the unit that raised it.

The decade ahead

A university's confidence in its own decisions is worth little if it cannot be checked. This plan does not ask Slop University to commit less over the decade ahead, or more cautiously than its ambitions require. It asks the University to be able to show, at any

point, the trajectory that justifies each commitment it has made — to a colleague, a candidate, a scholar, or a partner — and to keep asking the question rather than letting the first answer stand unchecked for the life of the commitment.

By 2031, the University's confidence in the people and partnerships it backs will rest on evidence it can produce on request, not memory of a decision made once and left behind. That is the standard this plan sets, and the standard it holds Slop University to keeping.

Every institution eventually learns which of its commitments it should not have made. This plan is Slop University's decision to find that out earlier, on the record, and by design, rather than later, informally, and by surprise.



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